

you **wrong** me!”

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN, 1802

Empire and revolution

Beethoven's staunchly independent attitude is often associated with the changes that were brought about by the French Revolution of 1789, which overthrew aristocratic and monarchical power in France. The “Eroica” Symphony was initially dedicated to Napoleon Bonaparte, the general of the Revolutionary armies; Beethoven erased this dedication when Napoleon declared himself emperor of the French in 1804, presumably because this assumption of an imperial throne was a betrayal of the principles of the Revolution. Yet Beethoven was no revolutionary republican. He also dedicated major works to Archduke Rudolf, a son of the emperor of Austria who was both his patron and his friend. In 1813, Beethoven wrote the patriotic Wellington's Victory (known as the “Battle Symphony”) to celebrate a victory of imperial Austria's British allies over the French in Spain.